Analysing Magyar

Course Project

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Contents

1 Introduction (*Bevezetés*)

Magyar, an Ugric language of the Uralic family, is spoken by approximately 13–14 million people, primarily in Hungary and adjacent Central European nations. Unlike the Indo-European languages that dominate the continent, Magyar shares its lineage with languages such as Finnish and Estonian, originating near the Ural Mountains. It is the most widely spoken Uralic language and serves as the official language of Hungary. This project aims to examine the structural features of Magyar, encompassing its history, phonology, morphology, syntax, and semantics.

2 History (*Előzmények*)

2.1 Origins and Early Development

Magyar belongs to the Ugric branch of the Uralic family, alongside Siberian languages such as Khanty and Mansi. Proto-Uralic, spoken several millennia ago near the Ural Mountains, gave rise to descendant languages now distributed across northern Eurasia. Linguistic and archaeological evidence traces the westward migration of proto-Magyar tribes over centuries. By the early Middle Ages, these nomadic populations inhabited the Eurasian steppes, engaging in sustained contact with Turkic peoples. This interaction profoundly influenced Magyar, evidenced by numerous early Turkic loanwords and the adoption of a runic script derived from Turkic models.

In 895 AD, Magyar tribes settled the Carpathian Basin, establishing the medieval Hungarian state. Following Christianisation around 1000 AD, Latin became the language of administration and religion, although Magyar remained the spoken vernacular.

2.2 Old to Modern Magyar

The Old Magyar period (circa 10th–16th centuries) witnessed the emergence of written Magyar, with the *Funeral Sermon and Prayer* (1192) representing the oldest surviving coherent text. This era concluded with the Ottoman victory at Mohács (1526) and the subsequent tripartite division of Hungary. The Middle Magyar period (16th–18th centuries) was characterised by regional dialectal divergence under varying Ottoman and Habsburg administrations, alongside an influx of Turkish vocabulary. Concurrently, literary output increased, notably with 16th-century vernacular Bible translations.

By the late 18th century, the Hungarian Enlightenment initiated the *nyelvújítás* (language reform). Reformers actively expanded the lexicon through neologisms and the revival of archaic terms, equipping Magyar for modern scientific and literary discourse. This culminated in 1844, when Magyar replaced Latin as the official state language. Subsequent standardisation solidified the modern literary language.

2.3 Demography and Dialectology

The Treaty of Trianon (1920) significantly altered Hungary's borders, resulting in substantial Magyar-speaking populations residing in neighbouring states. Today, of the estimated 13–14 million native speakers, nearly 10 million live in Hungary. Significant minority communities exist in Romania (approx. 1.2 million), Slovakia (approx. 450,000), and Serbia (approx. 250,000), with smaller populations in Ukraine, Croatia, Slovenia, and Austria.

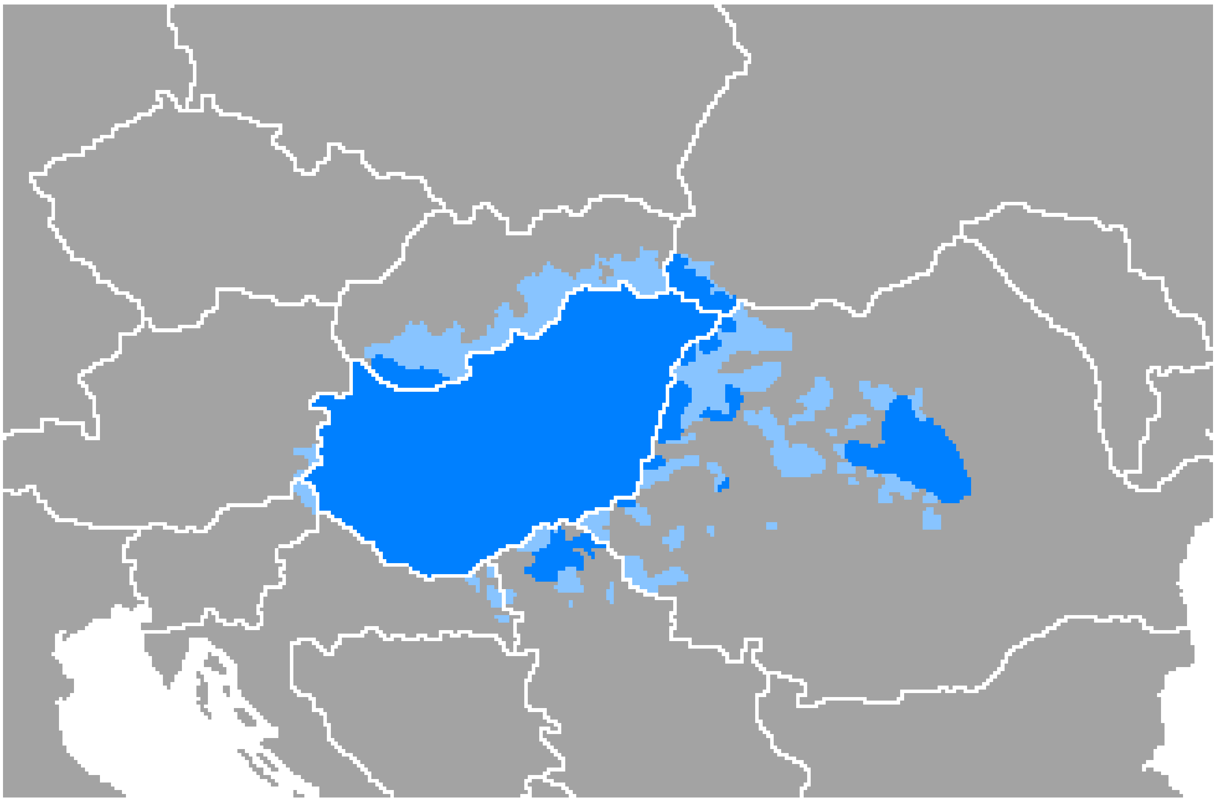

Figure 1: Distribution of Magyar speakers. Dark blue represents areas where the majority speaks Magyar natively; light blue represents minority populations.

Magyar dialectology generally identifies around ten regional varieties, which remain highly mutually intelligible, differing primarily in phonetics and lexicon rather than syntax or morphology. Standard Magyar is based on the Central (Pest region) dialect. Notable varieties include the conservative Székely and Csángó dialects spoken in Romania. While mass media has led to significant dialect levelling, regional accents remain discernible.

3 The Magyar Alphabet (*Magyar Ábécé*)

A a	Á á	B b	C c	Cs cs	D d	Dz dz	Dzs dzs	E e	É é
a	á	bé	cé	csé	dé	dzé	dzsé	e	é
[ɒ]	[aː]	[b]	[t͡s]	[t͡ʃ]	[d]	[dz]	[d͡ʒ]	[ɛ]	[eː]
F f	G g	Gy gy	H h	I i	Í í	J j	K k	L l	Ly ly
ef	gé	gyé	há	i	í	jé	ká	el	el ipsilon
[f]	[g]	[ɟ]	[h]	[i]	[iː]	[j]	[k]	[l]	[j]
M m	N n	Ny ny	O o	Ó ó	Ö ö	Ő ő	P p	R r	S s
em	en	eny	o	ó	ö	ő	pé	er	es
[m]	[n]	[ɲ]	[o]	[oː]	[ø]	[øː]	[p]	[r]	[ʃ]
Sz sz	T t	Ty ty	U u	Ú ú	Ü ü	Ű ű	V v	Z z	Zs zs
esz	té	tyé	u	ú	ü	ű	vé	zé	zsé
[s]	[t]	[c]	[u]	[uː]	[y]	[yː]	[v]	[z]	[ʒ]

Figure 2: Magyar Ábécé

Magyar is written using a modified version of the Latin alphabet. The standard modern alphabet consists of 44 letters, comprising a combination of single Latin characters, digraphs (two-letter combinations), and one trigraph (a three-letter combination).

A distinctive feature of the script is its treatment of digraphs and the trigraph as individual, indivisible letters within the alphabet. These include consonant clusters such as *cs*, *dz*, *gy*, *ly*, *ny*, *sz*, *ty*, and *zs*, as well as the trigraph *dzs*. When sorting words alphabetically in dictionaries or indices, these multi-character letters are treated as distinct entities rather than sequences of their component parts.

Furthermore, the script utilises diacritical marks extensively to represent the language's precise vowel inventory. Acute accents denote vowel length (as seen in *á*, *é*, *í*, *ó*, *ú*), whilst the umlaut is used for short front rounded vowels (*ö*, *ü*). Uniquely, Magyar employs the double acute accent to indicate the long counterparts of these front rounded vowels (*ő*, *ű*), a typographic feature specifically adapted for the language.

4 Phonology (*Hangtan*)

Magyar possesses a highly systematic and distinct phonological structure, which contrasts sharply with its Indo-European neighbours. Its core features include a rigid system of vowel harmony, strict phonemic length distinctions for both vowels and consonants, and a consistent initial-syllable stress pattern.

4.1 Vowel Inventory and Harmony

Magyar features 14 vowel phonemes, symmetrically divided into seven short and seven long counterparts. Vowel length is strictly phonemic and can independently alter the meaning of a word (e.g., *akar* 's/he wants' versus *akár* 'even if'). It is worth noting that for the lowest vowels, the length distinction also involves a significant shift in quality: the short *a* is a rounded back vowel /ɐ/, whilst its long counterpart *á* is an unrounded /aː/; similarly, the short *e* is an open-mid /ɛ/, whereas the long *é* is a close-mid /eː/. The presence of front rounded vowels (*ö*, *ü*, *ő*, *ű*) is a characteristic trait not commonly found in the immediate geographical region.

Vowel harmony is a fundamental governing principle of Magyar morphophonology. Suffixes typically possess two or three allomorphs designed to match the 'backness' of the root vowel. For instance, the inessive case manifests as *-ban* following back-vowel roots (e.g., *házban*, 'in the house') and *-ben* following front-vowel roots (e.g., *kézben*, 'in the hand'). Front unrounded vowels (/i/, /iː/, /ɛ/, /eː/) frequently act as 'neutral' or transparent vowels, meaning they can appear in roots alongside back vowels without forcing front-vowel harmony.

Height	**Front Unrounded**	**Front Rounded**	**Back Unrounded**	**Back Rounded**
Close	/i/, /iː/	/y/, /yː/		/u/, /uː/
Mid	/eː/, /ɛ/	/ø/, /øː/		/o/, /oː/
Open			/aː/	/ɐ/

Table 1: Magyar vowel phonemes

4.2 Consonant Inventory and Gemination

The Magyar consonant system is rich, featuring a full series of stops, fricatives, nasals, liquids, and affricates. A distinguishing feature is the presence of palatal stops (/c/, /ɟ/) and a palatal nasal (/ɲ/), written as *ty*, *gy*, and *ny* respectively. Historically, the language also distinguished a palatal lateral approximant (*ly*), but in standard modern Magyar this has merged entirely with the palatal approximant /j/ (*j*).

Consonant length (gemination) is fully phonemic across the inventory and occurs frequently in medial and final positions. A minimal pair illustrating consonant gemination is *hal* (/hɐl/, 'fish') versus *hall* (/hɐlː/, 'hears'), or *megy* (/mɛɟ/, 'goes') versus *meggy* (/mɛɟː/, 'sour cherry').

Manner	Bilabial	Labiodental	Alveolar	Postalveolar	Palatal	Velar	Glottal
Nasal	/m/		/n/		/ɲ/		
Plosive	/p/, /b/		/t/, /d/		/c/, /ɟ/	/k/, /g/	
Affricate			/ts/, /dz/	/tʃ/, /dʒ/			
Fricative		/f/, /v/	/s/, /z/	/ʃ/, /ʒ/			/h/
Approximant					/j/ (*j*, *ly*)		
Trill			/r/				
Lateral			/l/				

Table 2: Magyar consonant phonemes. The velar nasal [ŋ] occurs as an allophone of /n/ before velar consonants.

4.3 Prosody and Stress

Magyar exhibits a rigidly fixed stress pattern, with primary stress always falling on the first syllable of a word. This creates a highly predictable, trochaic rhythm in spoken Magyar. In longer, multisyllabic compound words, a secondary stress may fall on the first syllable of the subsequent compound elements, but the initial syllable of the entire word retains the most prominent auditory weight. Because stress is fixed, it is never used phonemically to distinguish meaning, unlike in languages such as English or Russian.

5 Morphology (*Alaktan*)

Magyar morphology is highly agglutinative: words are built by attaching chains of suffixes to stems, each adding one meaning or function. Nouns have no gender and two numbers (singular versus plural, marked by -*k*). Case roles (subject, object, location, etc.) are encoded by noun suffixes, and verbs by person/tense/mood endings (with separate patterns for definite versus indefinite objects). In derivation, affixes signal causation, aspect, reciprocity, and so on. Negation uses a separate word (*nem*) and does not attach to the verb. The table below lists major case suffixes with their glosses and example forms. Magyar suffix vowels obey vowel harmony (back versus front, rounded versus unrounded), and consonant/vowel alternations occur at suffix boundaries (e.g. final consonant devoicing or doubling).

5.1 Case Suffixes

Case	Gloss	Suffix	Example (stem + suffix)	Literal gloss
Nominative	(subject)	-	*ház*	‘house’
Accusative	definite object	*-t*	*ház-at*	‘house-ACC’
Dative	indirect object	*-nak/-nek*	*ház-nak*	‘to/for house’
Inessive	‘in’ locative	*-ban/-ben*	*ház-ban*	‘in house’
Superessive	‘on’ locative	*-on/-en/-ön*	*ház-on*	‘on house’
Adessive	‘at/near’ locative	*-nál/-nél*	*ház-nál*	‘at house’
Illative	‘into’	*-ba/-be*	*ház-ba*	‘into house’
Sublative	‘onto’	*-ra/-re*	*ház-ra*	‘onto house’
Allative	‘to’ (direction)	*-hoz/-hez/-höz*	*ház-hoz*	‘to house’
Elative	‘from inside’	*-ból/-ből*	*ház-ból*	‘from house’
Delative	‘off/from surface’	*-ról/-ről*	*ház-ról*	‘off house’
Ablative	‘from (general)’	*-tól/-től*	*ház-tól*	‘from house’
Translative	change into	*-vá/-vé*	*kő-vé*	‘into stone’
Terminative	‘until’ (time)	*-ig*	*hét-ig*	‘until week’
Causal-final	‘for (sake of)’	*-ért*	*ház-ért*	‘for house’
Essive-formal	‘as (role)’	*-ként*	*magyar-ként*	‘as Magyar’
Essive-modal	‘as (example)’	*-ul/-ül*	*ajándek-ul*	‘as gift’

Suffix vowels are determined by the stem’s vowel harmony: back-vowel stems take the *a, o, u* variants (*-ban, -nak, -on, -al, -at, -ol, -ul*, etc.), whilst front-vowel stems take *e, ö, ü* variants (*-ben, -nek, -en, -ül*, etc.), and roundedness adds a further alternation (e.g. *-val/-vel*, *-hoz/-höz*). For example, *házban* (‘in the house’) versus *kertben* (‘in the garden’).

Hungarian also marks possession with suffixes. For example, *házam* (‘my house’) is formed from the stem *ház-* plus *-am* (‘my’), and possession can stack with case: *házainkban* = *ház* + *-aink* + *-ban* = ‘in our houses’ (house + PL + 1PL.POSS + inessive). There is a genitive-like suffix *-é* for the possessive (e.g. *Jánosz* → *Jánosz-é*, ‘János’s’).

5.2 Verbal and Derivational Morphology

Verbs inflect for person (1/2/3), number, tense (present versus past; future is normally periphrastic with *fog*), and mood (conditional *-na/-ne*, subjunctive *-jon/-jen*, imperative *-j/-jen*, etc.). A key feature is definiteness: verbs take different endings depending on whether the object is definite. For instance, *Látok könyvet* means ‘I see a book’ (indefinite object) versus *Látom a könyvet*, ‘I see the book’ (definite object). Negation is a separate particle (*nem*) that precedes the verb.

Derivational suffixes add meanings or change valency. Causative suffixes (*-at/-et, -tat/-tet, -ztat/-ztet*) mean ‘cause to do X’ (e.g. *tanul*, ‘learn’ → *taníttat*, ‘have someone taught'). Frequentative or reciprocal actions use suffixes such as *-gat/-get* (e.g. *beszél*, 'speak' → *beszélget*, 'chat'). A passive-like voice can be formed with *-ul/-ül* (e.g. *válaszol*, 'answer' → *válaszolul*, 'be answered'), or more commonly by using the third-person plural as an impersonal construction. Adjectival and nominal suffixes include *-i* (forming adjectives or demonyms, e.g. *Budapest* → *budapesti*, 'from Budapest'), *-ság/-ség* (abstract nouns of quality, e.g. *fontos*, 'important' → *fontosság*, 'importance'), *-talan* ('without', e.g. *otthon*, 'home' → *otthontalan*, 'homeless'), and participial markers: *-ó/-ő* (present active participle, e.g. *futó fiú*, 'running boy'), *-ott/-ett* (past participle, e.g. *írt levél*, 'written letter'), and *-ás/-és* (verbal noun, e.g. *tanulás*, 'studying').

5.3 Relativisation

Relative clauses are introduced by relative pronouns: *aki* ('who', for people), *ami* ('which/that', for things), and *(a)melyik* ('which'), with appropriate case forms (e.g. *akit* for 'whom'). For example:

> *A férfi, aki itt lakik, orvos.*
> 'the man who here lives is-doctor' - "The man who lives here is a doctor."

The relative pronoun agrees in number and case with its role in the clause (e.g. *akit látok*, 'whom I see'). Participial or nominalised verb forms can also act like adjectives (e.g. *látó ember*, 'seeing man', for 'the man who sees'), but the pronoun strategy is more common. No special suffix is attached to the head noun for relativisation.

5.4 Examples and Analysis

ház + -aink + -ban	house + PL + P1PL.POSS + Inessive	'in our houses' (*házainkban*)
könyv-et olvas-ok	book-ACC read-1SG (indef. obj)	'I am reading a book'
a könyv-et olvas-om	DEF book-ACC read-1SG (def. obj)	'I am reading the book'
Az anya meg-ír-ja a levelet.	the mother PFV-write-3SG the letter-ACC	'The mother (completely) writes the letter.'
A tanár megtaníttat-ja a diák-okat.	the teacher CAUS-teach-3SG student-PL-ACC	'The teacher has the students learn.'
A férfi, aki itt lakik, orvos.	the man who here lives is-doctor	'The man who lives here is a doctor.'
Nem lát-om a kuty-át.	NEG see-1SG the dog-ACC	'I do not see the dog.'

6 Syntax (*Mondattan*)

Magyar typically follows Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) order in neutral sentences, much like English. However, it is a topic-prominent (information-structure-driven) language, so word order is highly flexible and depends on what the speaker wishes to emphasise. The topic (known information) generally comes first, and the focus (new or important information) immediately precedes the finite verb. For example, a neutral sentence might be *Péter eszi a kenyeret* ('Peter eats the bread'). To emphasise the bread, one can front it: *A kenyeret eszi meg Péter* ('It is the *bread* that Peter eats'), implying the bread (not something else) is being eaten. Emphasis in Magyar falls on the constituent immediately before the verb, so moving elements alters the sentence's meaning.

Magyar has no grammatical gender: the single third-person pronoun *ő* serves for 'he', 'she', or animate 'it'. (Because verb conjugations already encode person and number, even *ő* is often omitted unless needed for emphasis or clarity.) Adjectives and numerals precede the noun they modify (e.g. *piros alma*, 'red apple'; *három kutya*, 'three dogs'). There are definite (*a/az*, 'the', chosen by vowel harmony) and indefinite (*egy*, 'a/an') articles, and no separate plural article. Plurality is indicated on the noun itself by the suffix *-k* (for instance, *ház*, 'house', versus *házak*, 'houses').

Because Magyar marks grammatical roles with case suffixes, subjects and objects can switch places without ambiguity. For example, the accusative suffix *-t* marks the direct object, so *A kutyát szereti a gyerek* and *A gyerek szereti a kutyát* both mean 'The child loves the dog' (the suffix tells us 'dog' is the object). In this way cases carry relational meaning much like prepositions in English, freeing word order for emphasis. The language uses postpositions or suffixes for spatial and other relations (e.g. *házban*, 'in the house'; *házhoz*, 'to the house'; *házról*, 'from the house'), and possession is marked with suffixes as well (*házunk*, 'our house').

Placing an element in focus position highlights new or contrasting information. When focus appears, any separable verbal prefix often moves after the verb. For instance, the neutral sentence *Elvitte Péter a könyvet* ('Peter took the book away') becomes *Péter vitte el a könyvet* if the focus is on Peter, or *A könyvet vitte el Péter* if the focus is on the book. In all cases the case endings (such as *-t* on *könyv* in *könyvet*) still mark grammatical roles, but word order changes which part is emphasised.

Yes-no questions are formed with rising intonation or by adding the enclitic question particle *-e* to the verb. For example, *Eszi Péter a kenyeret?* or *Eszik-e Péter kenyeret?* both mean 'Is Peter eating the bread?' Content questions use question words such as *ki* ('who?'), *mi* ('what?'), *hol* ('where?'), *kinek* ('for whom?'), and *miért* ('why?'), which can also take case endings (e.g. *kit*, 'whom'; *miben*, 'in what?').

Negation is expressed by the particle *nem* placed immediately before the verb (the verb itself still takes the appropriate definiteness form). For example, *Péter nem eszi a kenyeret* means 'Peter does not eat the bread.' When using negative indefinites (such as *senki*, 'nobody', or *semmi*, 'nothing'), double negation is required (e.g. *Nem lát senkit*, 'He sees no one').

Relative clauses follow the noun they modify and are introduced by relative pronouns *aki* (for people) and *ami* (for things), which inflect for case. For instance, *A lány, akit láttam, az a tanárom* means 'The girl whom I saw is my teacher,' using *akit* ('whom', accusative of *aki*'). Subordinate clauses are typically linked with words such as *hogy* ('that') or *mert* ('because'), though *hogy* is often omitted in casual speech.

Overall, Magyar syntax relies on suffixes and word order together: verb forms encode person, number, and tense; case suffixes encode grammatical roles and relations; and the order of phrases (topic versus focus) signals emphasis. This combination allows Magyar to express complex ideas with flexible word order, emphasising different parts of the sentence as needed for information structure.

7 Semantics (*Jelentéstan*)

Magyar relies heavily on morphology and syntax to express semantic relations that are often encoded with prepositions or fixed word order in other languages. Case suffixes carry a great deal of meaning: *-ban/-ben* expresses location inside something (e.g., *házban*, 'in the house'); *-ba/-be* marks motion into something (e.g., *házba*, 'into the house'); *-ból/-ből* indicates motion out of something (e.g., *házból*, 'out of the house'); *-hoz/-hez/-höz* expresses direction towards something (e.g., *házhoz*, 'towards the house'); *-tól/-től* marks source or separation; *-nál/-nél* indicates proximity or possession at a location; and *-val/-vel* expresses accompaniment or instrument. In this way, semantic relations such as place, direction, source, means, and association are carried directly by suffixes rather than by separate function words.

A particularly important semantic distinction is that between definite and indefinite reference. The language uses articles and verbal agreement to distinguish whether a noun phrase refers to a specific, identifiable entity or to an unspecific one. This affects the meaning of the whole clause, since the verb itself changes according to the definiteness of the object. The contrast is visible in pairs such as *Látok egy házat* ('I see a house', indefinite) versus *Látom a házat* ('I see the house', definite), where the verb form changes entirely. As a result, definiteness is not merely a lexical property of nouns, but part of the clause-level semantics of Magyar.

Number is also semantically handled in a distinctive way. Cardinal numerals quantify nouns directly, and the noun generally does not need to appear in the plural after a numeral: thus *három ház* means 'three houses' with the noun remaining in its singular form. Quantity is therefore interpreted primarily through the numeral itself. Ordinal numerals identify position in a sequence and are semantically important in time, ordering, and measurement. Plural marking is consequently reserved for genuinely plural reference rather than simple quantification.

Body-part terms are usually interpreted through inalienable possession. Parts of the body are semantically tied to a possessor, and possessive morphology naturally appears with them. A form such as *a kezem* ('my hand') or *a feje* ('his/her head') is treated as an integrated possessor-possessed unit rather than as two independent nouns. This same pattern extends to other inherently linked nouns such as kinship terms.

Kinship vocabulary is especially rich in semantic distinctions. Magyar distinguishes relatives by generation, lineal versus collateral relation, and often by relative age: the system distinguishes mother (*anya*), father (*apa*), older brother (*báty*), older sister (*néne*), younger brother (*öcs*), younger sister (*húg*), son (*fiú*), and daughter (*lány*), among others. These terms also encode social structure and hierarchy and are frequently used as forms of address.

The language also expresses semantic nuances of causation and repeated action through morphology. Causative forms add the meaning 'make' or 'cause to', as in *itat* ('cause to drink', derived from *iszik*, 'to drink'). Frequentative or iterative morphology indicates repeated, habitual, or extended action, as in *olvasgat* ('to read repeatedly or leisurely', from *olvas*, 'to read'). These affixes shift the event structure of the clause, altering participant structure, level of control, or the aspectual profile of the action.

7.1 Levels of Politeness

Politeness in Magyar is a multi-tiered system encoded directly into the language's morphosyntactic structure, primarily through pronoun choice and verbal agreement paradigms, rather than a dedicated honorific vocabulary. Traditionally, it is described as a four-tier system, ordered from most to least deferential, although contemporary sociolinguistic pressures are causing significant shifts in its application.

Deferential address: *önözés* (*Ön*). Representing the highest formal register, *Ön* is the standard polite form used in official correspondence, institutional environments, and interactions with respected strangers. Crucially, although *Ön* functions semantically as a second-person pronoun ('you'), it dictates third-person singular verbal agreement. This grammatical indirection serves as a structural marker of maximum social respect.

Formal address: *magázás* (*maga*). Occupying the second tier, *maga* also utilises third-person singular agreement and is thus grammatically identical to *önözés*. The social implication, however, differs considerably. Whilst *Ön* is purely deferential, *maga* can imply deliberate social distance or lack of familiarity. Furthermore, it is not strictly symmetrical; a superior may address a subordinate using *maga* to assert a downward power dynamic, whereas the subordinate would be expected to reply with *Ön*.

Affectionate formal address: *tetszikezés* (*tetszik* + infinitive). This unique third tier employs the auxiliary verb *tetszik* (literally 'to please' or 'to like') to support the main verb. Grammatically identical in person to the previous two tiers, it is distinguished by a tone of affectionate deference. It is typically used by children addressing adults, or by adults addressing the elderly. By framing an action through the addressee's approval (e.g., *Hogy tetszik lenni?* – 'How do you please to be?'), the speaker softens the interaction and personalises the deference.

Informal address: *tegezés* (*te*). The least formal tier utilises the second-person pronoun *te* and its dedicated verbal paradigm. Historically restricted to family, close friends, peers, and children, its domain has expanded considerably. The influence of international corporate culture (with multinational companies adopting *te* in marketing to project egalitarian values) and the ubiquitous informality of the internet have made *tegezés* increasingly common in the public sphere, creating noticeable tension with traditional polite norms.

Pragmatic Strategies and Mitigation. Beyond pronoun selection, Magyar employs structural mitigation across all registers. The conditional mood is heavily utilised to soften requests and invitations; framing an imperative as a hypothetical scenario (e.g., *Hozna egy pohár vizet?* – 'Would you bring a glass of water?') significantly reduces its imposition. Additionally, lexical softeners (such as *talán*, 'perhaps') and collective institutional phrasing (employing first-person plural forms to distribute the force of a directive) are pervasive strategies to navigate social distance and project politeness.

8 Greenberg's Universals (*Greenberg-féle Univerzálék*)

While Magyar generally follows the universals stated by Greenberg, it flouts 3 of his maxims.

Universal 12: Interrogative Invariance

> "If a language has dominant order VSO in declarative sentences, it always puts interrogative words or phrases first in interrogative word questions; if it has dominant order SOV in declarative sentences, there is never such an invariant rule."

Greenberg posited that SOV languages lack invariant rules regarding the placement of interrogative words. Magyar complicates this assertion. It possesses a highly rigid, invariant rule regarding question words: they must occupy the immediately pre-verbal focus position. Whilst the subject or topic can theoretically precede the interrogative word-meaning the interrogative is not necessarily the absolute first word in the sentence (e.g., *Péter mit látott?*, 'Peter what saw?')-the syntactic slot it occupies is entirely inflexible. This demonstrates a level of structural rigidity for question words that Greenberg did not anticipate for SOV-tending languages.

Universal 16: Auxiliary Placement

> "In languages with dominant order SOV, an inflected auxiliary always follows the main verb."

Magyar is traditionally classified as having an underlying SOV word order, particularly evident in subordinate clauses and historically older structures. Universal 16 dictates that such a language must place its inflected auxiliary after the main verb. However, Magyar inflected auxiliaries frequently precede the main verb. For example, using the future auxiliary *fog*: *Én holnap fogok olvasni* (I will read tomorrow; literally "I tomorrow will-1SG read-INF"). Whilst the auxiliary can follow the main verb in specific, neutral contexts (*olvasni fogok*), the high frequency and dominance of the pre-verbal auxiliary directly challenge the absolute "always follows" constraint formulated by Greenberg.

Universal 23: The Apposition/Genitive Mismatch

> "If in apposition the proper noun usually precedes the common noun, then the language is one in which the governing noun precedes its dependent genitive."

Magyar presents a direct and well-documented falsification of this implicational rule. It satisfies the initial condition by placing the proper noun strictly before the common noun in appositional phrases. Titles and geographic descriptors always follow the proper name: *Kovács úr* (Mr Kovács; literally "Kovács Mr") or *Duna folyó* (Danube river).

According to Universal 23, Magyar must therefore place the governing noun before its dependent genitive. It does the exact opposite. In Magyar possessive constructions, the dependent genitive (the possessor) strictly precedes the governing noun (the possessed entity), as in *Péter háza* (Peter's house; literally "Peter house-his"). By pairing a Proper-Common appositional order with a Genitive-Noun possessive order, Magyar serves as a primary counterexample that led subsequent typologists to re-evaluate this universal.

9 Typological Comparison (*Tipológiai Összehasonlítás*)

Feature	Magyar	Tamil	Hindi
Language family	Uralic (Ugric)	Dravidian	Indo-Aryan
Morphological type	Agglutinative	Agglutinative	Fusional/analytic
Basic word order	SOV/SVO (flexible)	SOV (rigid)	SOV (flexible)
Case system	17+ cases	8 cases	3 forms
Grammatical gender	None	Animate/inanimate	Masculine/feminine
Definite article	Yes (*a/az*)	No	No
Object-definiteness agreement	Yes	No	No
Postpositions	Yes	Yes	Yes
Vowel harmony	Yes	No	No
Retroflex consonants	No	Yes	Yes
Aspirated stops	No	No	Yes
Pre-nominal relative clause	Yes (pronoun)	Yes (participial)	Yes (correlative)
Politeness system	4-tier pronominal	Diglossic + binary T-V	3-tier pronominal
Split ergativity	No	No	Yes (perfective)
Verbal preverbs	Yes (detachable)	No	No

Table 3: Typological comparison of Magyar, Tamil, and Hindi

9.1 Morphological Type

Magyar and Tamil are both strongly agglutinative. Both languages build morphologically complex words by stacking discrete, compositional suffixes on a root, each suffix contributing a single grammatical meaning. Magyar achieves forms such as *házainkban* ('in our houses') by concatenating stem, plural, first-person plural possessive, and inessive case suffixes; Tamil constructs equivalently dense verb forms by stacking tense, aspect, person, number, and gender markers. Hindi is substantially more analytic and partially fusional: its nominal morphology has been reduced to a nominative/oblique/vocative distinction, and relational meaning expressed by Magyar and Tamil case suffixes is instead conveyed by postpositions following the oblique form.

9.2 Case Systems

The three languages represent a clear gradient in case richness. Magyar has at least 17 productive cases encoding fine-grained spatial, directional, purposive, and formal relations, each expressed by a single dedicated suffix. Tamil has eight cases: nominative, accusative, dative, sociative, instrumental, locative, ablative, and vocative. Hindi has three morphological forms. All three mark the direct object distinctively: Magyar with the accusative suffix *-t*, Tamil with the accusative suffix *-ai* (and its allomorphs), and Hindi with the postposition *ko* following the oblique form (restricted to definite or animate objects). The progressive reduction from 17 to 8 to 3 reflects a cross-linguistic trade-off between suffixal case morphology and analytical postpositional constructions.

9.3 Definiteness and Articles

Magyar has a grammaticalised definite article (*a/az*) and an indefinite article (*egy*), and encodes definiteness a second time in verbal morphology: the verb takes a distinct conjugation paradigm depending on whether its object is definite (*látom a könyvet*, 'I see the book') or indefinite (*látok könyvet*, 'I see a book'). Neither Tamil nor Hindi has articles. Definiteness in both South Asian languages is left to demonstratives, discourse context, or bare nouns. The Magyar definiteness-agreement system has no parallel in either language; it is one of Magyar's most typologically distinctive features globally, not merely within this comparison.

9.4 Word Order and Information Structure

All three are SOV by default and verb-final in embedded clauses, consistent with Greenberg's Universal 4. However, the degree of surface flexibility differs. Magyar is the most pragmatically permissive: constituents move freely in response to topic-focus structure, with case morphology preventing role ambiguity. Hindi is moderately flexible, with SOV as a strong default. Tamil is the most consistently verb-final across clause types, permitting topicalisation and focus movement but resisting the freer permutations that Magyar allows. All three place the relative clause before its head noun. Magyar uses inflected relative pronouns (*aki, ami*); Tamil uses participial (non-finite) pre-nominal modification with no relative pronoun; Hindi uses a correlative structure pairing a *jo*-clause with a demonstrative in the main clause. These are three structurally distinct strategies for achieving the same pre-nominal relativisation outcome.

9.5 Agreement and Gender

Magyar verbs agree with the subject in person and number, and with the object in definiteness. There is no grammatical gender. Tamil verbs agree with the subject in person, number, and gender, where the gender system in the third person follows an animate/inanimate (rational/irrational) distinction rather than the masculine/feminine binary of Indo-European. Hindi verbs agree with the subject in gender and number, but split ergativity disrupts this in the transitive perfective, where the verb agrees with the object instead. Magyar has no ergativity; Tamil is consistently nominative-accusative. The Magyar definiteness-agreement system and Hindi's ergative object agreement are functionally parallel in that both encode object properties on the verb, but the mechanisms, triggers, and morphological forms are entirely unrelated.

9.6 Phonological Features

Magyar's phonology is defined by vowel harmony, phonemic vowel and consonant length, and fixed initial stress. Tamil has phonemic vowel length but no vowel harmony, and is distinguished by a three-way place contrast in stops - dental, alveolar, and retroflex - entirely absent from Magyar. Hindi has retroflex consonants and a full four-way aspiration/voicing distinction in stops (*p, p , b, b* , etc.) shared with Tamil but absent from Magyar. Magyar's front rounded vowels (*ö, ő, ü, ű*) and geminate consonants have no counterpart in either South Asian language. The two South Asian languages share more phonological features with each other (retroflex consonants, aspirated stops, contrastive vowel length) than either does with Magyar, despite Tamil and Hindi being genealogically unrelated.

9.7 Politeness and Register

Magyar operates a four-tier pronominal system (*önözés, magázás, tetszikezés, tegezés*), instantiated through distinct pronoun paradigms and their corresponding verbal agreement forms. Hindi uses a three-way pronominal distinction: *tū* (intimate or pejorative), *tum* (familiar), and *āp* (formal/respectful). This is structurally analogous to three of Magyar's four tiers, with the *tetszikezés* construction having no Hindi equivalent. Tamil encodes register through diglossia as much as through pronouns: the formal literary register (*centamil*) and the colloquial spoken register (*kotuntamil*) diverge substantially in vocabulary, morphology, and syntax, constituting effectively two different grammars for the same language. Within the spoken register, Tamil has a binary T-V pronoun distinction (*nī* informal versus *nīṅkaḷ* formal/plural). Magyar encodes social distance entirely within a single grammatical system; Tamil splits the encoding across a diglossic register division and a binary pronoun opposition.